Medical Assistants

Summary

Quick Facts: Medical Assistants	
2021 Median Pay	$37,190 per year $17.88 per hour
Typical Entry-Level Education	Postsecondary nondegree award
Work Experience in a Related Occupation	None
On-the-job Training	None
Number of Jobs, 2021	743,500
Job Outlook, 2021-31	16% (Much faster than average)
Employment Change, 2021-31	117,800

What Medical Assistants Do

Medical assistants complete administrative and clinical tasks in hospitals, offices of physicians, and other healthcare facilities.

Work Environment

Most medical assistants work in physicians' offices, hospitals, outpatient clinics, and other healthcare facilities.

How to Become a Medical Assistant

Most medical assistants have postsecondary education such as a certificate. Others enter the occupation with a high school diploma and learn through on-the-job training.

Pay

The median annual wage for medical assistants was $37,190 in May 2021.

Job Outlook

Employment of medical assistants is projected to grow 16 percent from 2021 to 2031, much faster than the average for all occupations.

About 123,000 openings for medical assistants are projected each year, on average, over the decade. Many of those openings are expected to result from the need to replace workers who transfer to different occupations or exit the labor force, such as to retire.

State & Area Data

Explore resources for employment and wages by state and area for medical assistants.

Similar Occupations

Compare the job duties, education, job growth, and pay of medical assistants with similar occupations.

More Information, Including Links to O*NET

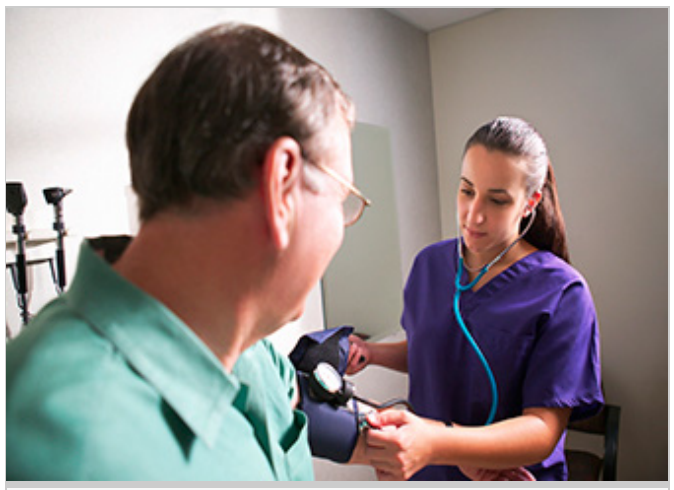
Learn more about medical assistants by visiting additional resources, including O*NET, a source on key characteristics of workers and occupations.

What They Do ->

What They Do

What Medical Assistants Do

Medical assistants complete administrative and clinical tasks in the offices of physicians, hospitals, and other healthcare facilities. Their duties vary with the location, specialty, and size of the practice.



Medical assistants often take medical histories and record vital signs of patients.

Duties

Medical assistants typically do the following:

- Record patient history and personal information
- Measure vital signs, such as blood pressure
- Help physicians with patient examinations
- Give patients injections or medications as directed by physicians and as permitted by state law
- Schedule patient appointments
- Prepare blood samples for laboratory tests
- Enter patient information into medical records

Medical assistants take and record patients' personal information. They must be able to keep that information confidential and discuss it only with other medical personnel who are involved in treating the patient.

Electronic health records (EHRs) are changing some medical assistants' jobs. More and more physicians are adopting EHRs, moving all their patient information from paper to electronic records. Assistants need to learn the EHR software that their office uses.

Medical assistants should not be confused with physician assistants, who examine, diagnose, and treat patients under a physician's supervision.

In larger practices or hospitals, medical assistants may specialize in either administrative or clinical work.

Administrative medical assistants often fill out insurance forms or code patients' medical information. They often answer telephones and schedule patient appointments.

Clinical medical assistants have different duties, depending on the state where they work. They may do basic laboratory tests, dispose of contaminated supplies, and sterilize medical instruments. They may have additional responsibilities, such as instructing patients about medication or special diets, preparing patients for x rays, removing stitches, drawing blood, or changing dressings.

Some medical assistants specialize according to the type of medical office where they work. The following are examples of ***specialized medical assistants***:

Ophthalmic medical assistants and optometric assistants help ophthalmologists and optometrists provide eye care. They show patients how to insert, remove, and care for contact lenses. Ophthalmic medical assistants also may help an ophthalmologist in surgery.

Podiatric medical assistants work closely with podiatrists (foot doctors). They may make castings of feet, expose and develop x rays, and help podiatrists in surgery.

<- Summary

Work Environment ->

Work Environment

Work Environment

Medical assistants held about 743,500 jobs in 2021. The largest employers of medical assistants were as follows:

Offices of physicians	58%
Hospitals; state, local, and private	15
Outpatient care centers	9
Offices of chiropractors	4

Medical assistants perform administrative and clinical tasks to keep the offices of health practitioners running smoothly.

Work Schedules

Most medical assistants work full time. Some work evenings, weekends, or holidays to cover shifts in medical facilities that are always open.

<- What They Do

How to Become One ->

How to Become One

How to Become a Medical Assistant

Most medical assistants have a postsecondary education award such as a certificate. Others enter the occupation with a high school diploma and learn through on-the-job training.

Assistants may update a patient's medical file, fill out insurance forms, and answer telephone calls in a practitioner's office.

Education

Medical assistants typically graduate from postsecondary education programs. Although there are no formal educational requirements for becoming a medical assistant in most states, employers may prefer to hire assistants who have completed these programs.

Programs for medical assisting are available from community colleges, vocational schools, technical schools, and universities and take about 1 year to complete. These programs usually lead to a certificate or diploma. Some community colleges offer 2-year programs that lead to an associate's degree. All programs have classroom and laboratory portions that include lessons in anatomy and medical terminology.

Some medical assistants have a high school diploma or equivalent and learn their duties on the job. High school students interested in a career as a medical assistant should take courses in biology, chemistry, and anatomy, and possibly business and computers.

Important Qualities

Analytical skills. Medical assistants must be able to understand and follow medical charts and diagnoses. They may be required to code a patient's medical records for billing purposes.

Detail oriented. Medical assistants need to be precise when taking vital signs or recording patient information. Physicians and insurance companies rely on accurate records.

Interpersonal skills. Medical assistants need to be able to discuss patient information with other medical personnel, such as physicians. They often interact with patients who may be in pain or in distress, so they need to be able to act in a calm and professional manner.

Technical skills. Medical assistants should be able to use basic clinical instruments so they can take a patient's vital signs, such as heart rate and blood pressure.

Training

Medical assistants who do not have postsecondary education certificates learn their skills through on-the-job training. Physicians or other medical assistants may teach a new assistant medical terminology, the names of the instruments, how to do daily tasks, how to interact with patients, and other tasks that help keep an office running smoothly. Medical assistants also learn how to code both paper and electronic health records (EHRs) and how to record patient information. It can take several months for an assistant to complete training, depending on the facility.

Licenses, Certifications, and Registrations

Medical assistants are not required to be certified in most states. However, employers may prefer to hire certified assistants.

Several organizations offer certification. An applicant must pass an exam and have taken one of several routes to be eligible for each certification. These routes include graduation from an accredited program and work experience, among others. In most cases, an applicant must be at least 18 years old before applying for certification.

The National Commission for Certifying Agencies, part of the Institute for Credentialing Excellence, accredits five certifications for medical assistants:

- Certified Medical Assistant (CMA) from the American Association of Medical Assistants
- Registered Medical Assistant (RMA) from American Medical Technologists
- National Certified Medical Assistant (NCMA) from the National Center for Competency Testing
- Certified Clinical Medical Assistant (CCMA) from the National Healthcareer Association
- Certified Medical Administrative Assistant (CMAA) from the National Healthcareer Association

Some states may require assistants to graduate from an accredited program, pass an exam, or both, in order to practice. Contact the state board of medicine for more information.

Advancement

With experience, medical assistants can specialize and move into leadership roles. With more education they may advance into other healthcare occupations such as registered nurse, physician assistant, or nurse practitioner.

<- Work Environment

Pay ->

Pay

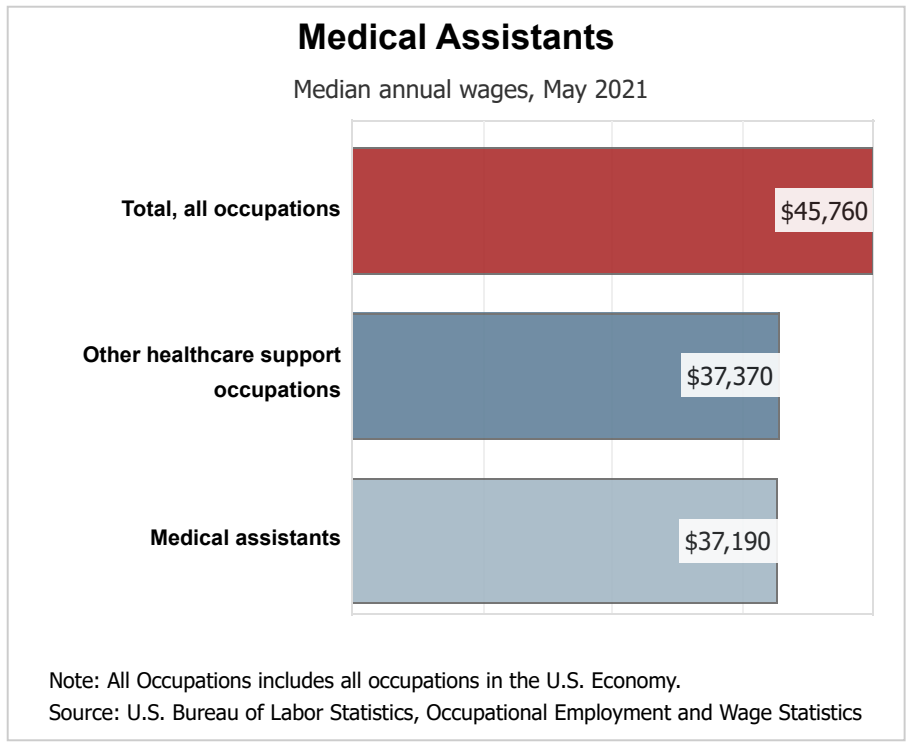
Pay

The median annual wage for medical assistants was $37,190 in May 2021. The median wage is the wage at which half the workers in an occupation earned more than that amount and half earned less. The lowest 10 percent earned less than $29,070, and the highest 10 percent earned more than $48,170.

In May 2021, the median annual wages for medical assistants in the top industries in which they worked were as follows:

Outpatient care centers	$38,270
Hospitals; state, local, and private	37,800
Offices of physicians	37,150
Offices of chiropractors	30,100

Most medical assistants work full time. Some work evenings, weekends, or holidays to cover shifts in medical facilities that are always open.



<- How to Become One

Job Outlook ->

Job Outlook

Job Outlook

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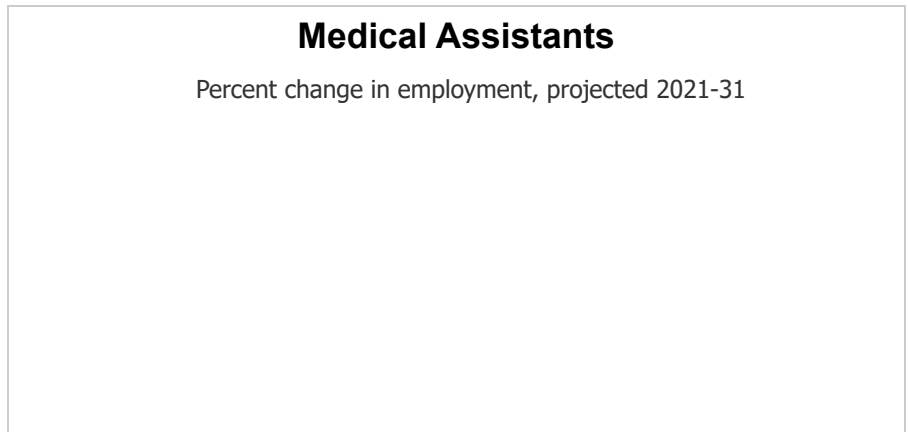
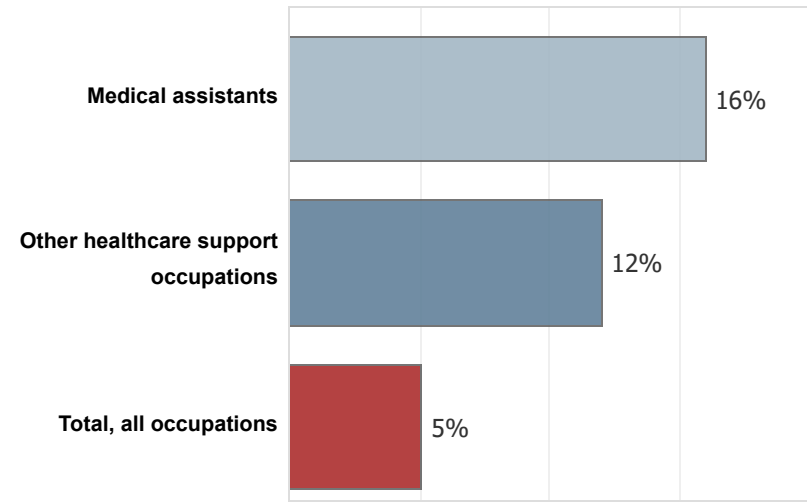


Employment

The large baby-boom population continues to enter older age groups, which typically have more healthcare concerns than younger age groups and will continue to increase demand for medical services. As a result, more medical assistants will be needed to perform routine administrative and clinical duties in physicians' offices and other primary care settings.



Note: All Occupations includes all occupations in the U.S. Economy.
Source: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Employment Projections program

Employment projections data for medical assistants, 2021-31

Medical assistants

SOC Code:
31-9092

Employment, 2021:
743,500

Projected Employment, 2031:
861,300

Change, 2021-31 (Percent):
16

Change, 2021-31 (Numeric):
117,800

Employment By Industry:
Get data

SOURCE: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Employment Projections program

<- Pay
State & Area Data ->

State & Area Data

State & Area Data

Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics (OEWS)

The Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics (OEWS) program produces employment and wage estimates annually for over 800 occupations. These estimates are available for the nation as a whole, for individual states, and for metropolitan and nonmetropolitan areas. The link(s) below go to OEWS data maps for employment and wages by state and area.

- Medical assistants

Projections Central

Occupational employment projections are developed for all states by Labor Market Information (LMI) or individual state Employment Projections offices. All state projections data are available at www.projectionscentral.org. Information on this site allows projected employment growth for an occupation to be compared among states or to be compared within one state. In addition, states may produce projections for areas; there are links to each state's websites where these data may be retrieved.

CareerOneStop

CareerOneStop includes hundreds of occupational profiles with data available by state and metro area. There are links in the left-hand side menu to compare occupational employment by state and occupational wages by local area or metro area. There is also a salary info tool to search for wages by zip code.

<- Job Outlook
Similar Occupations ->

Similar Occupations

Similar Occupations

This table shows a list of occupations with job duties that are similar to those of medical assistants.

Dental Assistants

Job Duties:
Dental assistants provide patient care, take x rays, keep records, and schedule appointments.

Entry-Level Education:
Postsecondary nondegree award

2021 Median Pay:
$38,660

Dental Hygienists

Job Duties:
Dental hygienists examine patients for signs of oral diseases, such as gingivitis, and provide preventive care, including oral hygiene.

Entry-Level Education:

Associate's degree

2021 Median Pay:
$77,810

Health Information Technologists and Medical Registrars

Job Duties:
Health information technologists and medical registrars advise organizations on computerized healthcare systems and analyze clinical data.

Entry-Level Education:
Associate's degree

2021 Median Pay:
$55,560

Licensed Practical and Licensed Vocational Nurses

Job Duties:
Licensed practical nurses (LPNs) and licensed vocational nurses (LVNs) provide basic nursing care.

Entry-Level Education:
Postsecondary nondegree
award

2021 Median Pay:
$48,070

Medical Records Specialists

Job Duties:
Medical records specialists compile, process, and maintain patient files.

Entry-Level Education:
Postsecondary nondegree
award

2021 Median Pay:
$46,660

Nursing Assistants and Orderlies

Job Duties:
Nursing assistants provide basic care and help patients with activities of daily living. Orderlies transport patients and clean treatment areas.

Entry-Level Education:
See How to Become One

2021 Median Pay:
$30,290

Occupational Therapy Assistants and Aides

Job Duties:
Occupational therapy assistants and aides help patients develop, recover, improve, as well as maintain the skills needed for daily living and working.

Entry-Level Education:
See How to Become One

2021 Median Pay:
$61,520

Pharmacy Technicians

Job Duties:
Pharmacy technicians help pharmacists dispense prescription medication to customers or health professionals.

Entry-Level Education:
High school diploma or
equivalent

2021 Median Pay:
$36,740

Phlebotomists

Job Duties:
Phlebotomists draw blood for tests, transfusions, research, or blood donations.

Entry-Level Education:
Postsecondary nondegree
award

2021 Median Pay:
$37,380

Physical Therapist Assistants and Aides

Job Duties:
Physical therapist assistants and aides are supervised by physical therapists to help patients regain movement and manage pain after injuries and illnesses.

Entry-Level Education:
See How to Become One

2021 Median Pay:
$49,180

Psychiatric Technicians and Aides

Job Duties:
Psychiatric technicians and aides care for people who have mental illness and developmental disabilities.

Entry-Level Education:
See How to Become One

2021 Median Pay:
$36,230

Contacts for More Information

For more information about becoming a medical assistant, including information on certification, visit

American Association of Medical Assistants

American Medical Technologists

National Center for Competency Testing

National Healthcareer Association

Institute for Credentialing Excellence

American Optometric Association

American Society of Podiatric Medical Assistants

Joint Commission on Allied Health Personnel in Ophthalmology

American Medical Certification Association

For lists of accredited educational programs in medical assisting, visit

Commission on Accreditation of Allied Health Education Programs

Accrediting Bureau of Health Education Schools

Medical Assistant Schools Directory

O*NET

Medical Assistants

<- Similar Occupations

SUGGESTED CITATION:

Bureau of Labor Statistics, U.S. Department of Labor, *Occupational Outlook Handbook*, Medical Assistants, at https://www.bls.gov/ooh/healthcare/medical-assistants.htm (visited *April 12, 2023*).

Last Modified Date: Tuesday, October 25, 2022